



RAKESH KUMAR: SHOWCASING INDIA'S BEST TO THE WORLD

Exhibitions and Expositions are great platforms for buyers and sellers to discover each other. And when they are on businesses that are spread throughout the vast expanse of our nation, such an imperative becomes essential to support and sustain them. India Exposition Mart has been doing just that.

Rakesh Kumar, the Founder Chairman of India Exposition Mart is a visionary. He conceptualised India's first state-of-the-art infrastructure for Exhibition and Mart at Greater Noida, popularly known as India Expo Centre & Mart.

Strategically located in Greater Noida, it has developed into a prominent MICE destination in India. With a covered area of 2,35,000 square meters, it is a world class venue with state of art facilities to host any business event. The India Expo Centre & Mart houses around 900 permanent showrooms of Indian exporters with 14 multi-purpose halls, 29 meeting rooms, 4 open areas and 4 speciality restaurants. It has a buyers' lounge, foreign exchange outlet, logistic support, extensive parking and Wi-Fi with modern secu-

urity & safety features. The venue will soon have a 128-bed hotel too. The facility has ISO 9001:2015, 14001:2015 and 45001:2018 certifications for Standalone MICE venue.

Major shows and Exhibitions Like Auto Expo, Printpack, IHGF Delhi Fair CPHI-PMEC, ELECRAMA, PLAST INDIA, DELHI WOOD and conferences like Asian Development Bank (ADB), FDI, NIIT, Anti-Tobacco Conference, World Dental Congress and CoP-14 have been held at this venue.

Expo Digital India Pvt. Ltd. (EDI) is the digital subsidiary promoting B2B business activities with permanent marts of manufacturers from across India at www.expobazaar.com. This marketplace provides endless opportunities to instantly connect with domestic and international buyers.

Kumar says, "I believe that the exhibition industry plays a

pivotal role in country's economy and the promotion of the brand INDIA message".

IEMI has won various awards and recognitions such as Satte Award 2020 for Best Exhibition Venue, Best Stand-Alone Convention Centre-National Tourism Award 2017-18 by Ministry of Tourism, Government of India, Best MICE Venue of India by TravTour MICE Guide, Winner for "Big Venue" Category – Exhibition Excellence Awards 2017 by Exhibition Showcase, Best Exhibition Centre by Safari India South Asia Travel etc.

As the Director General of the Export Promotion Council for Handicrafts (EPCH), Kumar spearheaded initiatives during the lockdown, turning adversity into an opportunity by launching the first virtual international B2B fair right here in India. EPCH went on to organise 10 virtual events including 6 virtual exhibitions and 4 Buyer Seller Meets during the COVID lockdown resulting in a growth of 1.62% in 2020-21. The Hon'ble Prime Minister of India lauded EPCH's thoughtful initiatives.

Kumar conceptualized the world-renowned Indian Handicrafts & Gifts Fair in 1994. The fair is recognised as 'World's largest congregation of handicrafts exhibitors under one roof' by Limca Book of World Records.

Kumar shares, "Exporters have successfully negotiated the difficult times with a lot of patience, positivity, hard work and courage. The future holds good business for everyone as we are getting back to normal."

Kumar promotes Product-specific shows like - Indian Furniture & Accessories Show, Indian Furnishings, Floorings & Textiles Show and Indian Houseware & Decoratives show and Indian Fashion Jewellery & Accessories Show. These shows are eagerly awaited by buyers from across the globe.

A strong advocate of traceability norms supporting legal Timber used in wooden handicrafts, Kumar postulated and introduced "VRIKSH" as its standard which is accepted by UN International organisation CITES (the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora) across 183 countries.

A trailblazer, Kumar is the brain behind the Common Facility Centre at Jodhpur and Saharanpur, Resource Centre at Moradabad, Handicrafts Productivity Centre and Testing Lab at Jaipur, International Lace Trade Centre at Narsapur, Trade Facilitation Centre at Jodhpur. He has been instrumental in the creation of Handicrafts & Carpet Sector Skill Council (HCSSC) to bridge the skill gap in the handicrafts & carpet sector and provide livelihood to over 2 million skilled manpower.

Rakesh Kumar has been appreciated across the globe for his contribution to the handicrafts, exports and MICE sector.

1. Japan Government's JETRO Commendation Award.
2. Super Achiever Award by Indiasgreatest.com
3. Safari India South Asia Travel Award for "the best Professional in MICE".
4. "THE IRON MAN" of The Exhibition Industry For 2016 at Exhibition Excellence Awards.
5. "Best MICE person" of the year in 14th Annual International Hospitality and Travel Awards 2018.
6. Special Felicitation Award for Merit - Flag bearer of the Industry by Exhibition Showcase 2022.